

e-Construct your Home

Homebuilding takes a lot of planning and coordinating and it's not something you're likely to do as often as remodelling.

Lafarge.com is one site you can consult before you kick-start your plans. It has a flowchart of the entire building process from start to finish, taking you through the purchase of land, legal issues and registration, getting the layout and foundation done to the right time for fixing doors and windows or the electrical connections and wiring.

Lafarge also has a budget planner, which is available as a downloadable Excel sheet. It covers all the details that go into the building of a house along with estimates of the total cost, helping you stay in control of your budget. The Time Scheduler lets you keep track of the time so that your dream home is ready right on target. This Excel scheduler has it all down perfectly—who should be involved in your project and at what stage of the project should plumbers or masons or painters start or finish work.

Lafarge also helps you identify who you need to engage to build or remodel your home and guidelines on how you should go about selecting the right architect or workers and getting the best out of them.

You can even search the Lafarge-India reference of books available in the market. The site also gives you addresses of bookstores where you can get your hands on home remodelling books.

At Asianpaints.com you can also find information on Vaastu and Feng Shui, and get free advice from the online design consultant.

Nerolac (www.nerolac.com) too has everything you need to know about painting your home, from planning to the actual painting process and how you should take care of the painted surfaces of your home.

There's an online guide to help you choose the right shade based on the existing colour scheme of your furniture or according to your personality. Just take a small personality test and find out the shade that suits you best. You can also use the online room visualiser to check out how different shades from the Nerolac colour palette would look on the interiors of different rooms, as well as find out the total cost of painting.

Buying your building blocks

If remodelling your home is a 'do-it-yourself' project you'll end up having to buy a lot of material yourself. To begin with, you'll need to have an idea of what's required. If you don't know cement from plaster, Lafarge has a guide that will tell you how to choose the best materials, whether it's cement, stone chips or water. The site also has a directory of dealers from whom you can buy building material.

If you're looking for a complete directory of home remodelling material then www.floor2roof.com is where you should head. It has an exhaustive range of almost every kind of building or home remodelling material—floorings, carpets, ceilings, roofing materials, wall finishes and furniture.

You can search for materials by category such as floors and roofs. Or if you're not quite sure, just select the room you want to remodel and you'll get a complete list of whatever materials you need to buy, whether it's doors, windows, furniture or lighting. View pictures of different finishes or products along with information on the product, the brand and the manufacturer or check out the price and add it to your wish list. You can also compare the features of the products added to your wish list if you aren't able to decide between the right kinds of windows for your home. Floor2roof has a directory of almost 20,000 outlets in every city and the products and building materials they deal in.

Hdfcrealty.com has an online catalogue of everything from antiques to drapes and furnishings, kitchen accessories, landscape equipment, plumbing equipment and where to locate it in a city. Dreamghar also has an online product finder with information on air-conditioners, glass works, tiles, natural stones and the city and store where you can locate it.

Find an architect online

Once you have all your planning in place, the next step is to find a professional who can trans-



Choose from home plans at Lafarge-India.com

late your dream home into reality. Locating a good architect for your bungalow or finding a plumber or mason isn't as easy as it seems. You would first look through classifieds in the newspaper or follow recommendations from neighbours, friends and relatives.

Find home improvement professionals such as architects, civil engineers, interior decorators and Vaastu consultants online from several Indian cities at Lafarge-India.com and Floor2roof.com.

Hdfcrealty.com has a vast list of professionals, which apart from interior decorators and architects, also include service providers such as air-conditioning dealers, carpenters, dealers in alternative energy like solar heaters, and fencing and fire protection engineers.

The final touches

There are a few limitations as Indian sites on remodelling just offer you basic help and advice to plan and budget your home remodelling efforts and locating professionals to get the job done. Nevertheless, the Net can be a valuable tool to help you plan your home remodelling and stay in control of your time and budget.

So the next time you're planning to remodel your home, take the help of your mouse and computer and you can assure your interior decorator a run for his money!

<http://www.indianinteriordesigns.com>
Check out the design gallery and directory of interior decorators

www remodelonline.com
This is where you should head for if you are looking for great remodelling ideas

www.diy.net
This site has a lot of useful information for 'do-it yourself' projects at home

www.buildingsteps.com
A portal for building professionals